

Paper 3: New Testament Studies

Overview

The content for this paper comprises a study of extended textual material. This study is set in a historical context so that students can become familiar with some of the more technical language and terminology used in the texts. It is also set in the context of the specific study of the Gospel texts, and involves a detailed understanding of the nature of selected passages of text as well as the scholarly and critical methods used today to study the text of the New Testament. There is a focus on understanding the Gospel teaching about how the first Christians understood the New Testament text and how they expressed and interpreted the relationship between Jesus and God.

Students will develop and extend their familiarity with the Gospel texts themselves and with the critical study of Christian beliefs about the status of the Bible and about Christian understanding of the meaning of the texts. They will be able to consider the views of important interpreters of the texts and contributors to the debate about the authority of the Bible in the Christian Church. **These studies will give students the opportunity to explore links between this paper and other areas of study, for example in relation to key Christian beliefs about the Trinity, Christian values in relation to the study of Ethics or the miracles of Jesus in relation to philosophical issues about their credibility.**

It is compulsory for students to compare the work of two named scholars, including a specific extract of their work. The list of extracts at the end of the paper must be studied by all students and this includes the work of two named scholars for comparison. These are published in the *A level Religious Studies Anthology: Paper 3 – New Testament Studies*, which can be downloaded from our website. The context in which these texts could be studied is indicated by bracketed numbers in the detailed content, (1) for example. These extracts are **not** exclusive to the topic areas under which they appear; students will need to be able to apply these extracts across any suitable topic.

This allows for a range of questions, including text or language specific, as well as thematic.

In this paper, students will be required to study the ideas of key contributors in relation to specific content areas. These are indicated against each relevant sub-topic. Students will be required to use these ideas to support and underpin their knowledge and understanding.

Overall, this study should give students the critical and scholarly tools they need to explore the Gospels. The study will also give them an understanding of how the early Christian communities understood Jesus and how Christians today interpret and apply the texts as a key source of authority.

Topics	What students need to learn	
1 Social, historical and religious context of the New Testament	1.1	Prophecy regarding the Messiah (1) a) The Suffering Servant of Isaiah, the importance of the line of David, the idea of the messianic secret. b) The significance of these expectations and their impact on New Testament texts, including Matthew's proof texts in the birth narratives and for understanding the Gospel texts. With reference to the ideas of R Brown and M Hooker.
	1.2	The world of the first century and the significance of this context for the life and work of Jesus a) Religious groups in Palestine. b) Hellenism. c) Roman occupation. d) The role and impact of these influences on legal and ethical dimensions of life in first-century Palestine and the relationship of Jesus' life and work to these influences.